



DECISIVE MOMENT June 6, 1944 6:35 a.m.

D-Day

After almost four years of planning, a combined American, British, Canadian, and Free French force launched Operation Overlord, aiming to wrest control of Europe from Nazi Germany. Beginning on D-Day with a five-pronged attack on the coast of northern France, the operation was to prove a crucial turning point in World War II.

The largest of the five assault areas was at Colleville-sur-Mer, codenamed Omaha Beach. Heavy Allied air and naval bombardment, effective at the other landing points, had made little impact on the well-prepared German defenses at Omaha, where the US 29th Infantry Division—untested in combat—attacked alongside the US 1st Infantry Division. Horrendous weather had forced General Dwight D. Eisenhower, Supreme Commander of the Allied forces, to delay the attack for 24 hours. The mission launched with little improvement in conditions, but further delay would have set the operation back by several weeks.

The adverse weather wrought havoc with the Allied landing craft: some sank in the rough seas, while German mines ripped through others. Of 29 amphibious tanks launched at Omaha Beach, 27 sank with their crews still trapped inside them. Many of the soldiers emerging from the landing craft were swept off their feet by heavy surf and drowned as they attempted to wade ashore, while others proved easy targets for German fire, picked off from the

clifftops as they struggled up the beach, weighed down by wet gear and heavy sand. The average age of the dead was 22. By early afternoon, American troops had managed to secure a small strip of beach, 6 miles (9.7 km) wide, and around 2 miles (3.2 km) deep. This patch of land came at a cost of 3,000 casualties.

Encountering less resistance at beaches codenamed Utah, Gold, Juno, and Sword, the Allies landed 150,000 troops by nightfall. Six days later they had linked the five beachheads into a continuous front and begun using artificial “Mulberry harbors” to land armored vehicles, heavy artillery, and more troops with which to further the advance. On June 27, after two weeks of intense fighting, American forces captured Cherbourg; on July 9 the British and Canadians overcame two Panzer divisions to take Caen; and on July 25 the tanks of the US 7th Army advanced south through Saint-Lô, breaching the German defenses. This was the vital breakthrough that led to the liberation of Paris on August 25 and, in early September, the crossing of the Siegfried Line into Germany.

Omaha beach

The first wave of troops to land at Omaha Beach arrived just before dawn. Photographer Robert Capa landed with them. Waist-deep in the icy sea with bullets tearing into the water around him, he captured the intense struggle as they fought their way onto the beach.

“We will accept nothing less than **full victory.**”

GENERAL DWIGHT D. EISENHOWER, D-DAY ORDER SPEECH, 1944